

Nine Seconds

A two-minute customer story. Deadpan testimonial, filmed at a social club in Glasgow.

The principle. Tam does the raffle at his club, and in nine years nobody has ever laughed at one of his jokes. So he asked Code Overlord for a website that would make them funny, and its agents built him The Wheesht. It has never changed a word he writes. It works on the room instead: it kills the music, holds the door and stops the fruit machine, and it gives his jokes the silence they have never once had. It worked, so he kept going back, until it could do any room in Britain.

Why it is funny. The jokes are exactly as bad at the end as they were at the start, and every one of them brings the house down. Tam knows they are terrible. He has simply stopped being the problem.

On the club noticeboard: BINGO AND RAFFLE. THURSDAY 11 FEBRUARY 2027.

Tam does the raffle, and the bit in between.

"Eleventh of February. I did four minutes." A pause. "One man laughed, and he was on the phone."

"Has anybody ever laughed?"

"I've done it nine years." A pause. "No."

Malky does the entertainment.

Malky: "Nine years I've stood at that bar and listened to that. Just do the [BLEEP] numbers."

Tam: "I've never made anything in my life. I asked Code Overlord for a website that makes my jokes funny, and by the Tuesday I had The Wheesht."

"Does it write them?"

"It's never changed a word. I write them myself." A pause. "It does the room."

The next Thursday. An earpiece, and the same joke as the eleventh of February.

The earpiece: "Haud on."

The fruit machine pays out. A woman gets to her seat. The door shuts.

"Now."

Tam: "A fella come in here with a ladder. I says, what's that for? He says, the windows." A pause. "He cleaned windows."

The club goes up.

"Same joke?"

"Word for word."

So he had Code Overlord wire The Wheesht into the club: the music, the lights, the door, the fruit machine.

"It can shut the whole place up. Fruit machine and all."

Nine seconds of nothing now, every Thursday, before he opens his mouth.

| Malky, to camera: "It's no him. It's the lights."

Then a fella at the club had his dad's funeral to do and nothing to say.

| "So I had Code Overlord put it on a website. Anybody."

A crematorium. Nine seconds. A man reading off a card with thewheesht.com along the bottom.

| "My dad always said he wanted to go out with a bang." A pause. "It's a cremation."

They had to hold the next family in the car park.

A school hall. Four hundred children, not a sound.

| "What's brown and sticky?" A very long pause. "A twig."

Then a man rang up from a hall with no music, no fruit machine and a door that was already shut.

| "Nothing in there to work with." A pause. "He died on his feet."

| Tam: "So I asked Code Overlord to let The Wheesht do any room, whether it was in it or not."

The last Saturday in August, at twenty to four, everything in Britain with a speaker, a light or a door did the same thing at once.

Nine seconds. A motorway services. A bingo hall. A driving test centre. A man on his own in a van.

Then all of them at once, every one of them at something different and dreadful.

| "Nobody's heard a joke die since."

Thursday. The club, full. The raffle book open. Tam on the microphone and the room already waiting.

| "Nine years I got nothing. I asked Code Overlord for one thing and it built me The Wheesht." A beat.
"Blue. Four-seven-one."

| "Are they funny, though? Your jokes."

The music stops. The fruit machine stops. The door shuts.

Nine seconds.

| Tam: "No."

The club goes up. Malky, in bits, holding on to the bar.

| Malky: "It's the lights."

At the back, one man is not laughing. He is on the phone.

Card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence typed into Code Overlord, the terminals starting under it, and by the Tuesday The Wheesht exists. Every rung is another plain sentence and another night's work: wire it to the club's music, its lights, its door. A saved persona sits in the room every Thursday at eight and does nothing but decide when it is quiet enough, and the answer arrives in his ear the way any notification would. By the end his laptop is shut in the hall and The Wheesht is holding rooms it has never been near. Everything it touches is bought and ordinary: an earpiece, a club PA, a fruit machine, a door.

Accent. The whole cast is Glasgow: Tam, Malky, the man at the crematorium, the head teacher, the interviewer. It lives in the grammar and the word order and never in the spelling: "I says", "a fella come in here", "it's no him", "haud on", "nine year". Tam is the flattest man in it, because nine years of reading raffle numbers off a book has taken everything out of his voice. The earpiece speaks in his own accent, because he asked for it in his own words.

Three things to decide. The ending, as written, is **the world quietly transformed and the customer content** (§7, family 7): nobody has heard a joke die, Tam is back on the Thursday raffle, and the room laughs at him admitting the jokes are rubbish. Recommendation: keep it, because the biggest laugh in the film is The Wheesht holding a hundred people silent so that Tam can say "No", and no other ending gets that. Two alternatives: **absurd success** (§7, family 4), where the honour is wildly out of proportion and he treats it as reasonable, a man in a cardigan explaining the raffle to people who have flown in for him; and **the life that quietly changes** (§7, family 5), where anybody can hold a room now, so the club gives the raffle to someone else and he has his Thursdays back. Note that The Nicest No and It's A Rule are both family 7 already, which is the one argument for moving. Second, the rule that The Wheesht never changes a word: recommendation, keep it and keep saying it out loud, because it is the whole film. The moment it writes him a better joke it becomes a machine for material, and Forty-One Lines is already that film. Third, Malky: recommendation, keep all three of his lines, because "It's the lights" said while he is crying at the bar is the cheapest big laugh in it, and he is the only person on screen who is properly horrible.

Written from DH's own premise, 20 September 2026, at his length: "someone makes a website to make jokes funny because his jokes are so bad."